

CORE FORMULA

Elicit -> Provide -> Elicit -> Elicit: "What do you already know about this?" or "Would it help to hear one option?" -> **Provide:** one clear point, briefly — "The main thing is X." -> **Elicit:** "What do you make of that?" or "How does that fit your situation?" -> **Minimum viable move:** "Would it be useful to hear one option? The option is X. What do you make of that?" -> **Field rule:** use the structure to organise your thinking, then speak like a person.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Run one light loop silently: ask whether an option would help, give one clear point, then ask what they make of it — without ever naming the framework.

BEST FOR

- Autonomy-sensitive advice
- Behaviour-change conversations
- Coaching and mentoring
- Clinical-style or expert explanations
- Giving feedback that needs to land
- Making a concise, memorable point in a meeting
- Offering an option without overriding the person's choice

PHRASE BANK

Opening elicits · Draw out first

- "What do you already know about this?"
- "Where are you up to with it so far?"
- "Would it help to hear one option?"
- "Want the short version or the full version?"
- "What have you tried already?"
- "What's your read on it so far?"
- "Can I offer one thought?"
- "What would actually be useful from me here?"

Asking permission · Permission before providing

- "Would it be alright if I shared what I've seen work?"
- "I've got a thought, if you'd like it — no pressure either way."
- "Happy to leave it, but I could offer one angle if that helps."
- "Can I share something, and you tell me whether it fits?"
- "Would it help to hear how others have handled this?"
- "I don't want to pile on — is now a good time for a suggestion?"
- "You know this better than I do, but can I add one thing?"

Providing briefly · One clear point

- "The main point is this — the rest is just support."
- "In short: X. I'll keep the detail for if you want it."
- "Here's the one thing worth knowing: X."
- "The headline is X; happy to go deeper wherever it's useful."
- "Let me give you the option first, then the reasoning."

- "If it helps, the approach I'd suggest is X."
- "That's the summary — where would you like me to expand?"

Closing elicits · Hand the meaning back

- "What do you make of that?"
- "How does that fit your situation?"
- "Does that match what you expected, or not quite?"
- "What lands, and what doesn't?"
- "What would you change about that?"
- "Where does that leave you?"
- "What's the one part worth acting on?"
- "What do you want to do with that?"

Softening and checking · When the structure over-runs

- "Let me check that was actually useful, not just tidy."
- "Tell me if I'm over-structuring this."
- "Say if that was more than you needed."
- "I can keep this short, and we can adjust it."
- "If that frame isn't landing, we can drop it."
- "What part was useful, and what should we lose?"

Advice under pressure · Sensitive or high-stakes

- "This is your call — I'll offer what I know, then step back."
- "Before I say anything, what matters most to you here?"
- "I'll give you one option, but the decision stays with you."
- "Would information help right now, or would you rather I just listened?"
- "Here's the risk as I see it — how does that sit with you?"
- "I could be wrong about this, so tell me how it reads from your side."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Announces the framework and forces every sentence into Elicit -> Provide -> Elicit, sounding rehearsed.
Better: Uses the structure silently to organise one concise, easy-to-follow response.
Best: Uses it flexibly, drops it the moment it stops helping, and checks whether the listener is clearer, more heard, and better able to respond.
2. Weak: Asks a question, ignores the answer, and delivers the advice anyway.
Better: Asks, then tailors the information to what the answer revealed.
Best: Asks, adapts, and lets the closing question genuinely change what happens next.

DECISION TREE

If The listener needs speed

Use the shortest version — one option, one line, one check.

"Quick version: I'd go with X. Does that work for you?"

If The listener needs support

Validate the feeling first and delay the framework.

"That sounds hard. Do you want ideas yet, or not right now?"

If The listener needs a story or example

Switch to an example-led neighbour such as STAR or CARL.

"Let me give you a concrete example of how that played out."

If The listener needs to act

End on one clean next step rather than more information.

"So the next step is X — shall we start there?"

If The listener already sounds clear

Stop providing; hand it over and let them run with it.
"Sounds like you've got it — what's your first move?"

If The listener challenges the framing

Drop the structure, summarise, and invite correction.
"Fair — tell me where I've got this wrong."

SCENARIOS

Contributing in a work meeting

Use one light loop to make the point concise and memorable rather than rambling. — "Do we want options or a recommendation? Mine is X — how does that sit?"

Advice or an update by email

Put each step in short, scannable paragraphs or bullets so the reader can follow at a glance. — "Quick question, one suggestion, then over to you — reply with whatever fits."

Giving feedback

Elicit what kind of feedback would help before you provide any. — "Do you want the headline or the detail? ... Here's the one thing. What's your take?"

A difficult or sensitive conversation

One sentence per step, then pause and let them fill the space. — "Can I offer one thought? ... It's X. ... What do you make of that?"

Coaching or mentoring

Lead with their own knowledge so your input adds rather than replaces. — "What have you already ruled out? ... Then the option left is X. Worth a try?"

Explaining something you're the expert on

Check what they already understand so you pitch the one point at the right level. — "What's your understanding so far? ... The key thing is X. ... Does that clear it up?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- You intend to ignore their response anyway
- A brief, direct instruction is what's actually needed
- Physical safety or an emergency takes priority
- Strong emotion is present and needs validation or repair first
- The person has already decided and just wants to be heard
- You are using the questions to steer rather than to genuinely ask

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Draft one loop

Write a 60-second response to a real advice moment using Elicit -> Provide -> Elicit, naming each step to yourself as you go.

Day 2 — Cut it down

Cut that response by a third — then again to about 30 seconds — without losing the core point.

Day 3 — Two voices

Say it aloud twice: once as a visible structure, once as ordinary speech. Notice which one you'd want to be on the receiving end of.

Day 4 — Test the value

Ask of each version: would this actually help the other person understand, decide, or act? Cut anything that only makes you sound polished.

Day 5 — Real opening elicit

In one real conversation, use only the opening elicit — draw out what they know or want before you offer anything.

Day 6 — Full loop, hidden

Run the whole loop in a live conversation without naming the framework, and watch whether they get clearer or more able

to act.

Day 7 — Practise recovery

Deliberately over-structure once, then use a recovery line to simplify and hand the point back to the other person.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I use the structure to serve the listener, or just to sound polished?
- Were my questions real, or decoration around advice I'd already decided to give?
- Was the core point clear and brief?
- Did I adapt the moment the listener needed something else?
- Did I preserve their autonomy and dignity?
- Did clarity actually improve for them?